

militarily, was surrounded by enemy forces. The South Vietnamese surrendered the base with hardly a shot fired.

With the loss of Camp Carroll went all the Vietnamese Marines' artillery and the ARVN's heaviest guns. The US advisers stationed there only just escaped in time, while some 1,500 ARVN soldiers were captured. Pressure against the remaining South Vietnamese positions in Quang Tri province immediately increased and a full-scale ARVN retreat was soon underway.

“ [The] **disorder** and **panic** among these refugees ... was **contagious**. ”

GENERAL NGO QUANG TRUONG DESCRIBING CIVILIANS FLEEING QUANG TRI, 2010

The bridge is blown

Following the loss of Camp Carroll, General Gai ordered his forces to withdraw behind the Cua Viet River, setting up a battle for the town of Dong Ha. This was a critical location because the bridge carrying the main north–south transportation route, Route 1, crossed the river there. A second bridge, built by the French, stood nearby, and a third bridge crossed the river near Camp Carroll. The three crossings formed the gateway to the heart of Quang Tri province and the cities of Hue and Da Nang.

By April 2, the Vietnamese Third Marine Battalion, ordered up from reserve, had entered the town, along with the 20th Armored Squadron on M-48 Pershings, the ARVN's heaviest tanks. To the north, across the river, the North Vietnamese tanks had taken up positions. Before they could sweep across the Route 1 bridge, Colonel Turley ordered Captain John Ripley, top adviser to the Third Marines, to blow up the bridge. Captain Ripley displayed extreme bravery and skill as he climbed through the steel structure of the bridge to set the explosives. The blast destroyed both the road bridge and the railway crossing.

10,000 The estimated number of NVA troops killed in the battle for Quang Tri City.
5,000 The estimated number of ARVN killed in the retaking of Quang Tri city.

Fresh attacks

By forcing the NVA tanks to make a lengthy detour westward to cross the river, the destruction of the bridge at Dong Ha effectively sapped the momentum of the NVA advance. Supplies to their forces also had to be replenished. The interruption provided the ARVN with time to regroup its forces and attempt a counteroffensive, but without much effect. On April 23, the North Vietnamese renewed their attacks, this time slowly grinding away in an attempt to wear down ARVN morale.

The ARVN forces abandoned Dong Ha on April 28, and Quang Tri was lost on April 29. Cloud cover had prevented US air strikes in support of the ARVN.

The loss of Quang Tri and the NVA bombardment of villages and towns in the area led to a mass of refugees fleeing down Route 1 toward Hue. The NVA targeted the road, and the loss of civilian lives there comprised one of the worst atrocities of the war.

In the wake of this catastrophic defeat, President Thieu replaced Military Region 1 commander Lam with General Ngo Quang Truong, South Vietnam's best field commander. General Gai was fired, tried by a military tribunal, and sentenced to jail, his place taken by Nguyen Duy Hinh.